

Progress made by EU candidate countries on accession-related reforms

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The European Union enlargement process is both politically driven and merit-based. Politically, the process is driven by the determination of a candidate country to join the EU, and the willingness of incumbent EU countries to let it in. In terms of merit, becoming an EU member requires adopting the EU *acquis communautaire* – the accumulated body of EU law – codified in 35 negotiation chapters and grouped into six thematic clusters.

This paper analyses the progress made by EU candidate countries on accession-related reforms using a novel method involving the quantification of the European Commission's annual qualitative assessment of countries' preparedness. The results of our analysis are contrasted with the actual status of accession negotiations for each country.

To some extent, progress in accession negotiations is tracking progress in *acquis* adoption. This is especially visible for Montenegro, the most advanced EU candidate in terms of reform. Montenegro could complete accession negotiations in 2026 or early 2027. However, there are also opposite examples where, despite good reform scores, negotiations have stalled, as in the case of North Macedonia.

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1 Introduction

The European Union's accession process is both politically driven and merit-based. Politically, the process is driven by the political determination of a candidate country to join the EU, and willingness of incumbent EU countries to let it in. In terms of merit, becoming an EU member requires adopting the EU *acquis communautaire*, codified into 35 negotiation chapters, grouped since 2020 into six thematic clusters. Ideally, the political dimension of the EU enlargement process should be determined by a merit-based assessment – that is, the candidate's progress in adopting the *acquis*. In reality, however, adopting the *acquis* and formal accession negotiations sometimes diverge for political reasons. The requirement for unanimous consent by all EU countries to approve each step in accession negotiations is the main factor causing such divergence. Occasionally, the domestic political considerations of an incumbent or its bilateral disputes with a candidate prevail over a merit-based assessment of its preparedness to join the EU.

In this Working Paper, our analysis focuses on the candidates' progress in adopting the *acquis*, based on the European Commission's annual reports (the so-called enlargement packages), which assess the level of preparedness of individual candidates for EU membership and their progress in EU accession-related reforms¹. Following the methodological approach of Emerson and Blockmans (2025), we translate these annual Commission assessments into numeric scores for each negotiation chapter and then aggregate them into the chapters' thematic groups and overall reform progress. To reflect the various degrees of difficulty in adopting individual negotiation chapters, we apply respective weights. We cover eight candidate countries in the Western Balkan and Eastern Europe regions²: Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, North Macedonia and Serbia, for the period 2020-2025, and Georgia, Moldova and Ukraine for the period 2023-2025.

To bring in the political dimension of the accession process, we compare the results of our analysis with the actual progress of EU accession negotiations.

We start our analysis by discussing details of our methodological approach in section 2. In section 3, we present the reform progress for individual chapters by each candidate country for 2020-2025. Section 4 analyses the overall reform progress by negotiation clusters per country. Our results are compared with other reform or governance rankings in section 5, and then the actual status of accession negotiations in section 6. Section 7 contains policy conclusions and recommendations.

Occasionally, the domestic political considerations of incumbents prevail over a merit-based assessment of candidates' preparedness to join the EU

1 See, for example, European Commission news of 4 November 2025, 'Commission reports on the progress of aspiring EU members', https://commission.europa.eu/news-and-media/news/commission-reports-progress-aspiring-eu-members-2025-11-04_en; and accompanying country reports. Similar news and reports were published in 2020-2024.

2 Kosovo is excluded from the analysis because of differences in the Commission's reporting structure. Türkiye, for which accession negotiations were frozen by the Council of the European Union in 2018, is also not included. See the European Commission factsheet on Türkiye, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/turkiye_en.

2 Methodology

Our methodological approach borrows from Emerson and Blockmans (2025). However, we build on their contribution in at least three ways. First, we conduct a dynamic analysis for six years instead of one year. Second, we apply weights to assess the difficulty in negotiating individual chapters and carrying out related reforms. Third, we use interim assessments verbatim, which the other authors do not, therefore allowing for more granularity in our scores.

2.1 Data sources

Our assessment of the progress in the EU accession-related reforms is based on the annual enlargement reports published by the Commission³. Candidate countries are assessed on their efforts to align their legislation, institutions and practices with the 33 EU accession negotiation chapters⁴. The Commission's reports provide a narrative qualitative assessment for each country and chapter, typically evaluating both the level of preparation (ie the extent of alignment with EU *acquis*) and the progress made over the preceding year. These assessments are expressed through standardised qualitative labels that appear explicitly in each chapter of the reports, which are consistent across years and countries.

2.2 Data collection and structure

For Western Balkan countries, the analysis covers the period from 2020 to 2025. However, for Ukraine, Moldova and Georgia, which were granted candidate status only in 2022-2023, the time coverage is more limited and begins in 2023.

We constructed a novel dataset based on the Commission's enlargement reports from 2020 to 2025, which were collected and systematically processed to extract chapter-level assessments (Bruegel Dataset, 2026).

The unit of analysis is defined at the country-year-chapter level, covering up to 33 chapters per country-year. This structure allows for consistent comparison across countries and over time.

A large language model (LLM) was used to read these reports and extract the qualitative assessments of the level of a country's preparation for and alignment with the *acquis*.

2.3 Translating qualitative assessment into quantitative scores

Quantifying qualitative characteristics is always a difficult and disputable exercise. However, it is the only available tool to measure progress in different policy areas and

³ Each country's enlargement report contains a methodological note referring to a variety of sources, including contributions from the government of the candidate country, EU countries, European Parliament reports and from various international and non-governmental organisations. It also includes the results of comparative assessments and indices produced by other stakeholders, in particular for rule of law (see European Commission, 2025).

⁴ Chapters 34 (Institutions) and 35 (Other issues) are not covered by the annual Commission assessments.

conduct a cross-country comparative analysis of various aspects of governance and regulation. It also allows the dynamic analysis of regulatory and policy changes in individual countries over time.

Once the Commission’s assessments were catalogued, we translated them into an ordinal scale. The full mapping between the Commission’s verbatim categories and the numerical values assigned in this paper is presented in Table 1.

Table 1: Commission qualitative assessments of the level of preparation and respective numerical scores:

Commission assessment (verbatim)	Ordinal value	Standardised score (0-100)
Early stage	1	0
Between the early stage and some level of preparation	2	13
Some level of preparation	3	25
Between some and a moderate level of preparation	4	28
Moderately prepared	5	50
Between a moderate and a good level of preparation	6	63
Good level of preparation	7	75
Between a good and advanced level of preparation	8	88
Well advanced	9	100

Source: Bruegel.

This ordinal scale has been subsequently transformed into continuous indicators on a 0-100 scale, preserving their ranking while enabling comparison and aggregation across chapters, countries, time and other surveys.

The dataset combines automated extraction with manual verification to ensure robustness. A subset of observations was cross-checked against the original reports, and systematic inconsistencies were addressed through harmonisation rules and targeted corrections.

2.4 Weights reflecting the chapters’ complexity and reform difficulty

The reform agendas required by each negotiation chapter are unequal in terms of their implementation difficulty. To address this problem, we apply a set of weights ranging from 1 to 4 to each chapter (Table 2).

The negotiation chapters were weighted according to their relative implementation difficulty. In assigning weights, six dimensions were considered: (1) the scale of legislative harmonisation required; (2) the administrative and technical capacity needed for implementation; (3) the need for specialised or independent institutions; (4) the extent of inter-ministerial coordination required; (5) the financial and infrastructural costs of compliance; and (6) the political sensitivity and enforcement difficulty associated with the *acquis* area.

The highest weight (4) was adopted for Chapters 23 (Judiciary and Fundamental Rights) and 24 (Justice, Freedom and Security), which constitute the core of the ‘Fundamentals’

cluster and are widely regarded as the backbone of EU conditionality. These chapters require not only legislative approximation, but also sustained improvements in judicial independence, rule of law, anti-corruption frameworks, border management, asylum systems and the protection of fundamental rights.

Table 2: Negotiation chapters' difficulty weights

Chapter number	Chapter name	Cluster	Weight
1	Free movement of goods	Internal Market	2
2	Free movement for workers	Internal Market	2
3	Right of establishment and freedom to provide services	Internal Market	2
4	Free movement of capital	Internal Market	2
5	Public procurement	Fundamentals	2
6	Company law	Internal Market	2
7	Intellectual property law	Internal Market	3
8	Competition policy	Internal Market	3
9	Financial services	Internal Market	2
10	Information society and media	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	2
11	Agricultural and rural development	Resources, Agriculture & Cohesion	3
12	Food safety, veterinary and phytosanitary policy	Resources, Agriculture & Cohesion	2
13	Fisheries	Resources, Agriculture & Cohesion	2
14	Transport policy	Green Agenda & Sustainable Connectivity	3
15	Energy	Green Agenda & Sustainable Connectivity	3
16	Taxation	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	1
17	Economic and monetary policy	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	1
18	Statistics	Fundamentals	1
19	Social policy and employment	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	1
20	Enterprise and industrial policy	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	1
21	Trans-European Networks	Green Agenda & Sustainable Connectivity	1
22	Regional policy and coordination of structural instruments	Resources, Agriculture & Cohesion	2
23	Judiciary and fundamental rights	Fundamentals	4
24	Justice, freedom and security	Fundamentals	4
25	Science and research	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	1
26	Education and culture	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	1
27	Environment and climate change	Green Agenda & Sustainable Connectivity	3
28	Consumer and health protection	Internal Market	1
29	Customs union	Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth	2
30	External relations	External Relations	1
31	Foreign, security and defence policy	External Relations	1
32	Financial control	Fundamentals	2
33	Financial and budgetary provisions	Resources, Agriculture & Cohesion	1

Source: Bruegel.

Chapters 7 (Intellectual Property Law) and 8 (Competition Policy) receive weights of 3 because they require more complex regulatory frameworks, strong enforcement institutions and significant administrative capacity. Effective implementation in these areas depends not only on legal transposition, but also on the capacity to ensure market oversight, state aid control, competition enforcement and judicial effectiveness.

The weights of 3 are also attributed to Chapter 11 (Agriculture and Rural Development) and several chapters within the 'Green Agenda and Sustainable Connectivity' cluster, notably transport, energy and environment. These policy areas involve substantial financial costs, large-scale infrastructure investment and long-term structural transformation. Alignment with the EU *acquis* in these fields often requires extensive public investment, administrative coordination and implementation over many years.

The intermediate weights (2) have been applied to most of the 'Internal Market' and 'Resources, Agriculture & Cohesion' chapters (considering reforms that EU candidates already conducted during implementation of association and free trade agreements with the EU), two 'Fundamentals' chapters ('Public Procurement' and 'Financial Control') and a few others.

Chapters with intermediate or lower weights generally involve less institutionally demanding forms of *acquis* alignment, or areas in which substantial approximation had already occurred through earlier association agreements with the EU.

For each negotiation chapter, weighted scores are equal to: Chapter Score (0-100) × Weight. Cluster scores are calculated as weighted averages across all chapters belonging to the same enlargement cluster: Cluster Score = Sum (Score × Weight) / Sum (Weight). Overall country scores are calculated as weighted averages across all *acquis* chapters: Overall Score is equal to: Sum (Score × Weight) / Sum (Weight)

3 Reform progress by individual chapters, 2020-2025

Figure 1 presents the annual advancement of reforms in 2020-2025 by each candidate country and negotiation chapter⁵.

Table 3 presents a summary of Figure 1 in the form of simple averages of individual chapter scores.

Table 3 shows Montenegro leading, followed by three other Western Balkan countries: Serbia, North Macedonia and Albania. Montenegro also recorded a visible acceleration in the reform process in 2024-2025, like Moldova, which, however, lags behind the leadership group. On the other hand, Serbia and North Macedonia, despite their relatively higher scores, recorded very slow progress. The scores of Bosnia and Herzegovina and Georgia have stagnated at low levels.

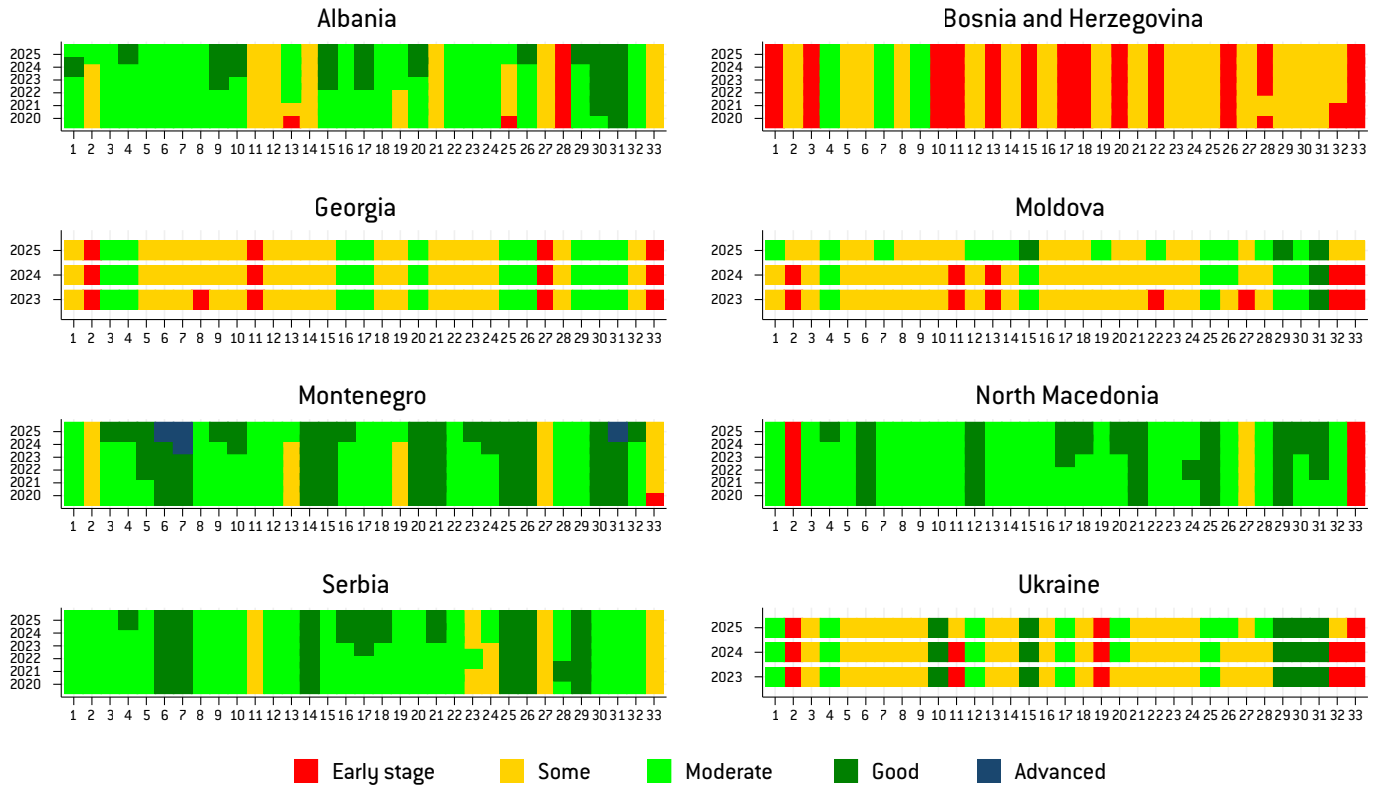
However, these are unweighted averages, which do not reflect the difficulty of completing individual chapters and their relative importance for the accession process. For example, looking at chapters 23 and 24, considered as the most difficult to adopt (and sustain) and most important for the progress in accession negotiations⁶, only

⁵ For Georgia, Moldova and Ukraine the analysis covers only 2023-2025, subject to data availability.

⁶ See European Commission, 'Rule of Law', undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/enlargement-policy/policy-highlights/rule-law_en.

Montenegro recorded in 2025 a 'good' level of preparation (Figure 1). Other candidates recorded either a 'moderate' (Albania, North Macedonia, Serbia in Chapter 24) or 'some' level of preparation.

Figure 1: The level of preparation, by negotiation chapter, 2020-2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025. Note: for the chapter names, see Table 2. For Georgia, Moldova and Ukraine, comparable assessments are available only from 2023.

Table 3: Progress in adoption of *acquis*, 2020-2025, an overall unweighted average of chapters' scores

Country	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Albania	38	41	41	44	46	47
Bosnia and Herzegovina	16	16	17	17	17	17
Georgia	n/a	n/a	n/a	28	28	28
Moldova	n/a	n/a	n/a	23	25	36
Montenegro	52	53	53	53	55	61
North Macedonia	50	50	51	51	52	53
Serbia	51	52	52	51	53	53
Ukraine	n/a	n/a	n/a	32	32	34

Source: European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025, authors' estimates.

4 The weighted scores of reform progress, 2020-2025

In this section, we analyse the overall weighted scores and compare them with the unweighted ones, followed by the analysis of weighted scores by clusters.

4.1 Overall scores

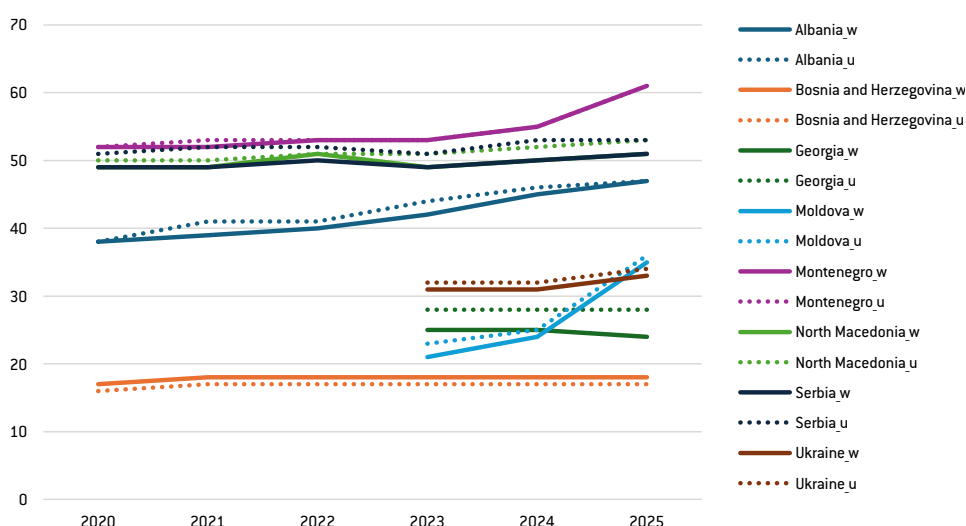
Table 4 presents the weighted averages of individual chapter scores. Figure 2 compares them with the unweighted averages shown in Table 3.

Figure 2 superficially suggests that overall weighted scores do not differ much from unweighted ones. However, a more detailed analysis shows that, in most cases, they are marginally lower (by 1 point) than unweighted averages. In Montenegro, these scores have been the same since 2022. In Georgia, the gap is bigger: 2-3 points, depending on the year.

Bosnia and Herzegovina is the exception, with overall weighted scores higher than the unweighted ones by 1-2 points, depending on the year. This likely reflects the country's relatively stronger performance in the negotiation chapter on intellectual property law, which was assigned a higher weight than most other chapters. Nevertheless, among all analysed candidates, it is the least advanced in adopting *acquis*.

The weighted averages also allow for the identification of reform-reversal episodes unseen in unweighted averages. This relates to Serbia and North Macedonia (both in 2023) and Georgia (2024).

Figure 2: Evolution of overall weighted and unweighted preparedness scores, 2020-2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025. Note: solid lines represent overall weighted average preparedness scores and dotted lines represent overall unweighted average preparedness scores.

Table 4: Progress in adoption of *acquis*, 2020-2025, an overall weighted average of chapters' scores

Country	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025
Albania	38	39	40	43	45	47
Bosnia and Herzegovina	17	18	18	18	18	18
Georgia	n/a	n/a	n/a	25	25	24
Moldova	n/a	n/a	n/a	21	24	35
Montenegro	52	52	53	55	55	61
North Macedonia	49	49	51	49	50	51
Serbia	49	49	50	49	50	51
Ukraine	n/a	n/a	n/a	31	31	33

Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025.

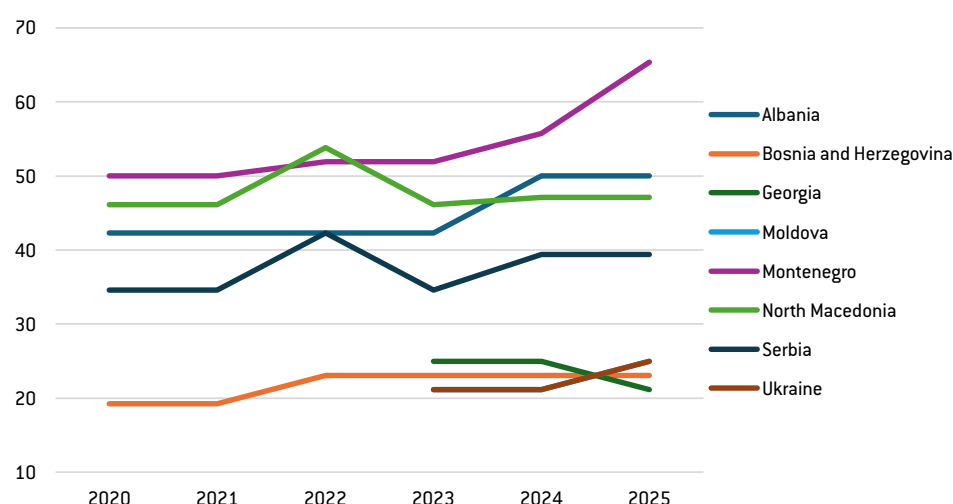
The ranking of individual countries in adoption of the *acquis* and the speed of accession-related reforms looks similar when one uses the weighted and unweighted averages. Montenegro is the undisputed leader, followed by Serbia, North Macedonia and Albania. The Western Balkan region (except Bosnia and Herzegovina) is more advanced than the Eastern European candidates. Montenegro and Moldova have demonstrated the most visible acceleration of reforms since 2023, while in Albania progress has been slower but systematic since 2022.

Montenegro and Moldova have demonstrated the most visible acceleration of reforms since 2023

4.2 Cluster scores

In this subsection, we assess candidate countries' performance across six negotiation clusters, using the weighted chapter scores presented above. This allows us to identify not only overall progress towards EU accession, but also the specific policy areas in which countries are advancing or lagging.

Figure 3: Evolution of weighted preparedness scores in the Cluster 1 'Fundamentals', 2020-2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025. Note: Moldova's score matches that of Ukraine, whose line overlaps it.

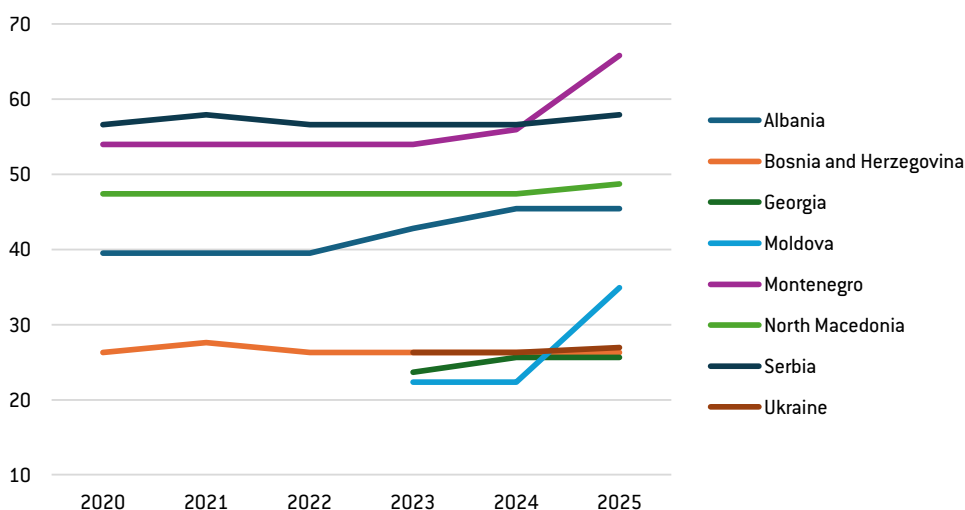
We start our cluster analysis from the Cluster 1 'Fundamentals', the most difficult to adopt in new democracies and politically the most important to be admitted as a new EU member.

Figure 3 shows an even larger gap between the Western Balkan candidates and the Eastern European ones – plus Bosnia and Herzegovina – than in the overall scores (Figure 2). However, two of four leaders suffered substantial reform reversals in 2023 (North Macedonia by 7 points, and Serbia by 8 points) and were overtaken by Albania. More generally, fluctuations in 'Fundamentals' scores help to explain the incidences of deterioration in overall scores analysed in section 4.1.

Again, Montenegro has been an undisputed leader, recording a systematic improvement in this category since 2022.

Cluster 2 ('Internal market') is also difficult in terms of *acquis* adoption. However, some progress has already been accomplished and anchored during the implementation of bilateral association and free trade agreements with the EU. Hence, Cluster 2 scores look more stable (Figure 4). In most cases, there is slow or no progress over time. Montenegro, Moldova and Albania saw more progress after 2022. In 2025, Montenegro recorded the highest score of 66, followed by Serbia (58), North Macedonia (49), Albania (45), Moldova (35), Bosnia and Herzegovina (27), Georgia (26), Ukraine (26), and Georgia (both 26). Again, there is a gap between the four Western Balkan candidates and Eastern European ones (plus Bosnia and Herzegovina).

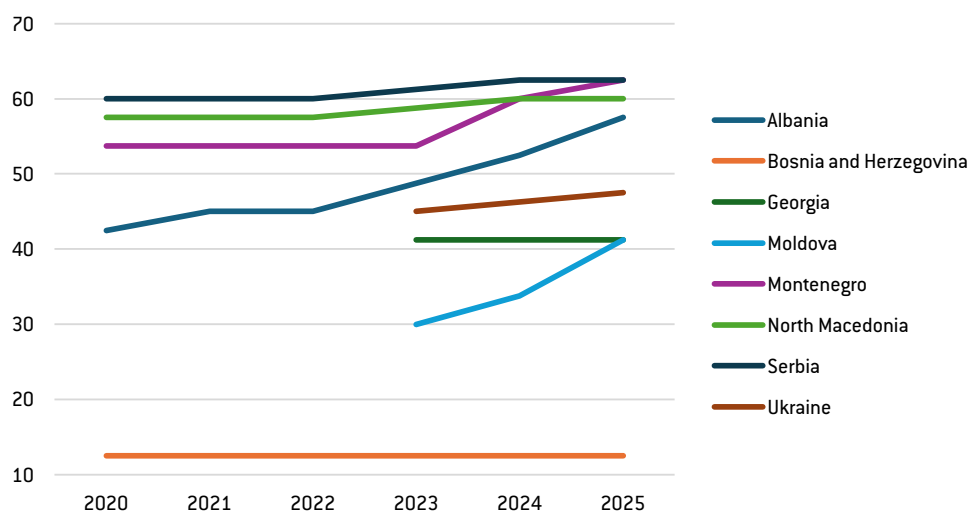
Figure 4: Evolution of weighted preparedness scores in the Cluster 2 'Internal Market', 2020-2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025.

A somewhat similar picture is presented by Figure 5 for Cluster 3 ('Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth') with one important difference: a smaller gap between four Western Balkan leaders and three Eastern European countries (but with Bosnia and Herzegovina still lagging behind others).

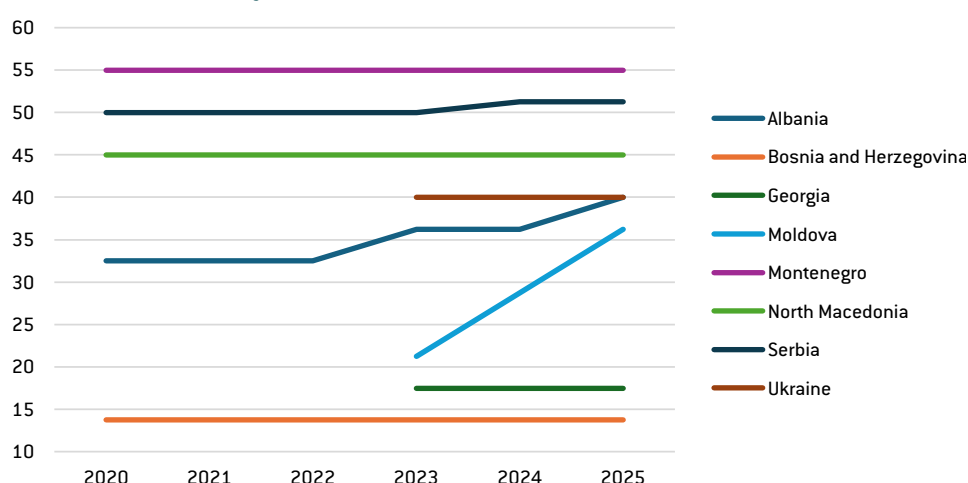
Figure 5: Evolution of weighted preparedness scores in the Cluster 3 'Competitiveness & Inclusive Growth', 2020-2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025.

As mentioned earlier, Cluster 4 ('Green agenda & sustainable connectivity') can be considered as the second most difficult cluster after 'Fundamentals'. Figure 6 shows a moderate level of reform advancement and lack of progress during the analysed period, except for Moldova, Albania (both starting from low levels of preparedness), and, marginally, Serbia. Unlike in Clusters 1-3, there are smaller differences between the four Western Balkan and three Eastern European countries, with Ukraine having higher scores in 2023-2024 than Albania, but contrary to the latter, recording no progress.

Figure 6: Evolution of weighted preparedness scores in the Cluster 4 'Green agenda & sustainable connectivity', 2020-2025

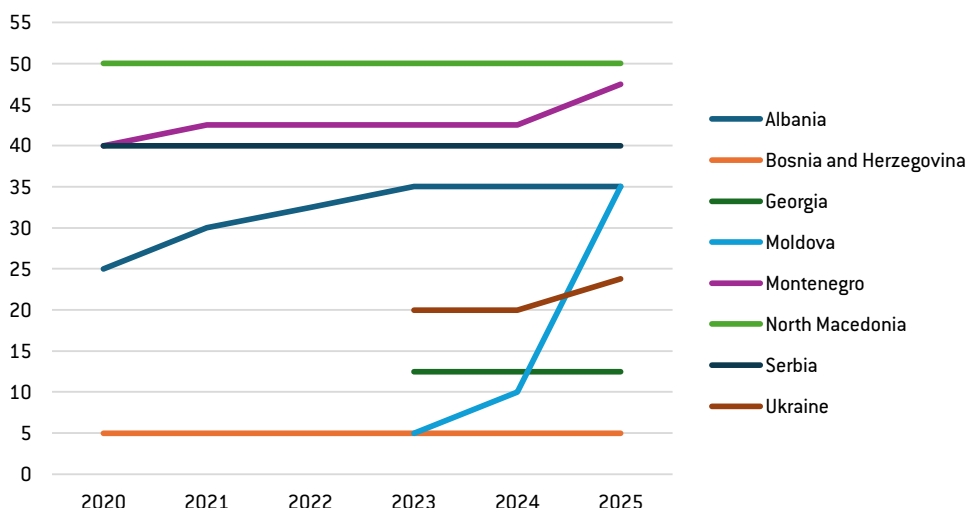


Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025.

A similar picture can be obtained in the Cluster 5 'Resources, agriculture & cohesion' (Figure 7): moderate levels of advancement, smaller interregional differences, but more progress in the analysed period. Moldova recorded rapid progress from a very low level, Albania had significant progress (but from a slightly higher starting point than Moldova)

and Montenegro and Ukraine recorded moderate progress. In 2025, North Macedonia was a leader in this category (the score of 50), followed by Montenegro (47), Serbia (39), Albania and Moldova (both 33), Ukraine (24), Georgia (13) and Bosnia and Herzegovina (6).

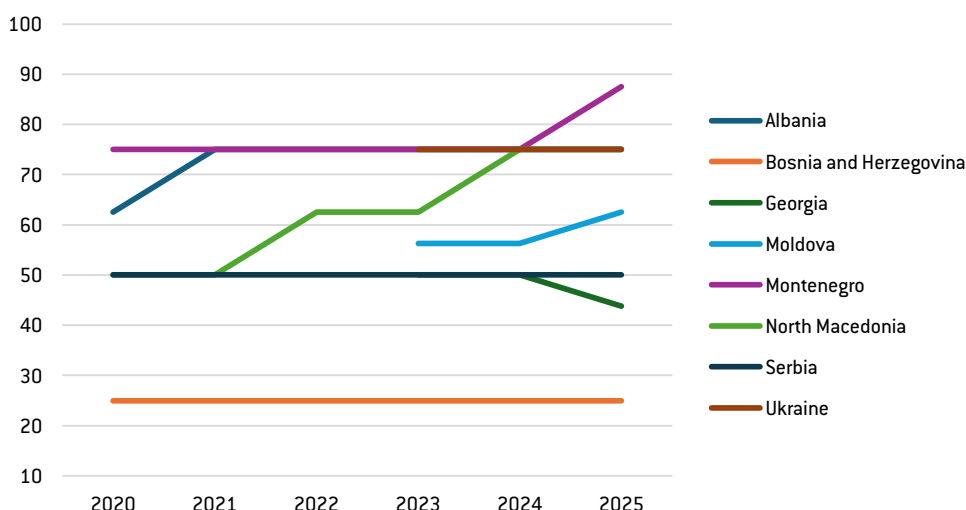
Figure 7: Evolution of weighted preparedness scores in the Cluster 5 'Resources, agriculture & cohesion', 2020-2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025.

Cluster 6 'External relations' includes only two chapters (30 and 31) with weights of 1 in our analysis (Figure 8). In 2025, four countries represented a high degree of alignment with *acquis*: Montenegro (the score of 88), Albania, North Macedonia and Ukraine (all three at 75). They were followed by Moldova (63), Serbia (50), Georgia (44, a deterioration from 2022-2023), and Bosnia and Herzegovina (25).

Figure 8: Evolution of weighted preparedness scores in the Cluster 6 'External relations', 2020-2025

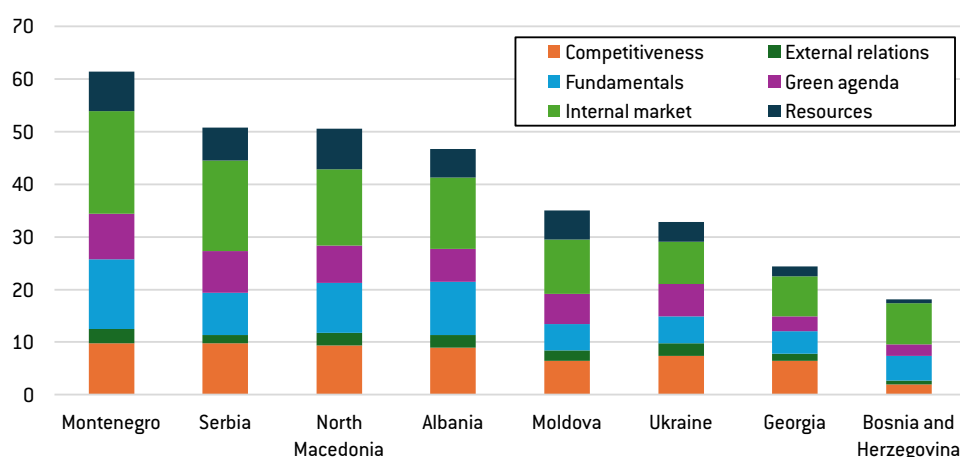


Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual 'enlargement packages', 2020-2025.

Finally, Figure 9 shows the contribution of six clusters to the overall weighted scores in 2025. The decomposition is based on the weighted chapter preparedness scores

within each cluster, expressed as a share of the country's total weighted preparedness score. This allows us to identify which policy areas contribute most to the overall level of *acquis* alignment in each candidate country. In all analysed countries except Bosnia and Herzegovina, the main contribution comes from reforms conducted in Clusters 2 and 3. Montenegro, North Macedonia and Albania can claim a significant contribution coming from reforms in Cluster 1. Other candidates are less advanced in the alignment with the *acquis* in this politically most important cluster. Overall, the picture offered by Figure 9 is in line with our earlier findings (Figures 3-8).

Figure 9: Decomposition of weighted preparedness scores by cluster, 2025



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission annual enlargement packages, 2025.

5 Comparison with other surveys

Changes in economic, political and institutional systems are the subject of many global surveys. For a comparison with the results of our analysis, we chose the World Bank's World Governance Indicators (WGIs; World Bank, 2025) and the 'well-governed' scores developed by the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development (EBRD), one of its six qualities of a sustainable market economy⁷. In both cases, the comparison has an indicative character, but due to differences in the assessed content, applied scales and weights and other methodological discrepancies, it cannot be considered an exact comparison of the same characteristics.

5.1 World Bank WGIs

The WGIs consist of scores for six indicators on a scale of 0-100 for the years 2020-2024. These indicators are Voice and Accountability, Rule of Law, Political Stability, Government Effectiveness, Regulatory Quality and Control of Corruption. Hence, we can

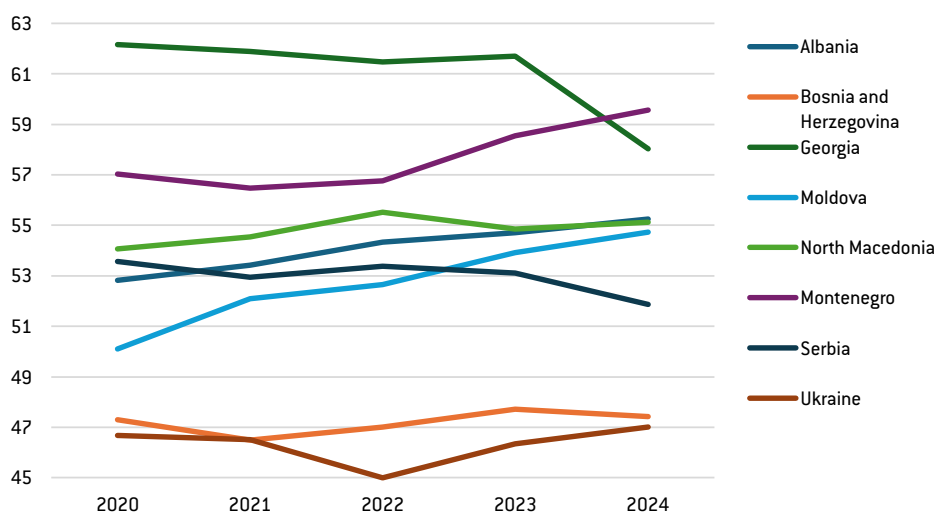
⁷ See the EBRD, "'Well governed': the EBRD's transition concept", undated, <https://www.ebrd.com/home/who-we-are/ebird-values/ebird-transition/well-governed.html>.

consider them as an additional assessment of public governance and institutions, largely covered by Cluster 1 ('Fundamentals') of the accession negotiations.

It is important to note, however, that the WGIs differ substantially from our *acquis*-based scores in both methodology and scope. While our accession scores measure the degree of alignment with the EU *acquis* and progress in adopting and implementing specific EU rules, legislation and institutional requirements, the WGIs reflect a broader perception-based assessment of governance quality and state capacity. In particular, the WGIs aggregate information from surveys of firms, citizens, experts and international organisations, capturing how institutions function in practice rather than formal compliance with EU accession benchmarks.

At the beginning, we calculated simple averages of six WGI scores, presented in Figure 10. When comparing it with our 'Fundamentals' weighted scores (Figure 11), we see one striking difference: the leadership of Georgia, only overtaken by Montenegro in 2024.

Figure 10: World Governance Indicators, simple average of six dimensions, 2020-2024



Source: Bruegel based on the World Bank.

It seems that Georgia benefitted, for a long time, from radical institutional, deregulation and anti-corruption reforms in the second half of the 2000s, during the presidency of Mikhael Saakashvili (Steenland and Gigitashvili, 2018), which strengthened state capacity and improved regulatory quality. This was also reflected in other global and regional surveys, such as the World Bank's Doing Business (published until 2020)⁸, Transparency International Corruption Perception Index⁹, or Heritage Foundation Index of Economic Freedom¹⁰. They have not necessarily focused on the alignment with the EU *acquis*; rather, they reflected business and experts' opinions.

Georgia's reform gains from the second half of the 2000s have gradually eroded,

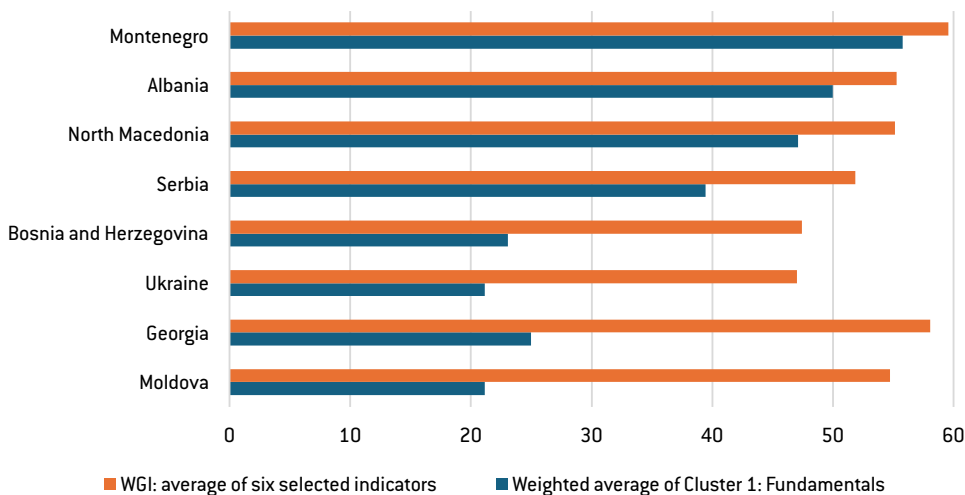
⁸ See World Bank, 'Ease of Doing Business scores', undated, <https://archive.doingbusiness.org/en/scores>.

⁹ See Transparency International, 'Corruption Perceptions Index – Georgia (2022)', undated, <https://www.transparency.org/en/cpi/2022/index/geo>.

¹⁰ See the Heritage Foundation, 'Economic Freedom Country Profile – Georgia', February 2026, <https://economicfreedom.heritage.org/pages/country-pages/georgia>.

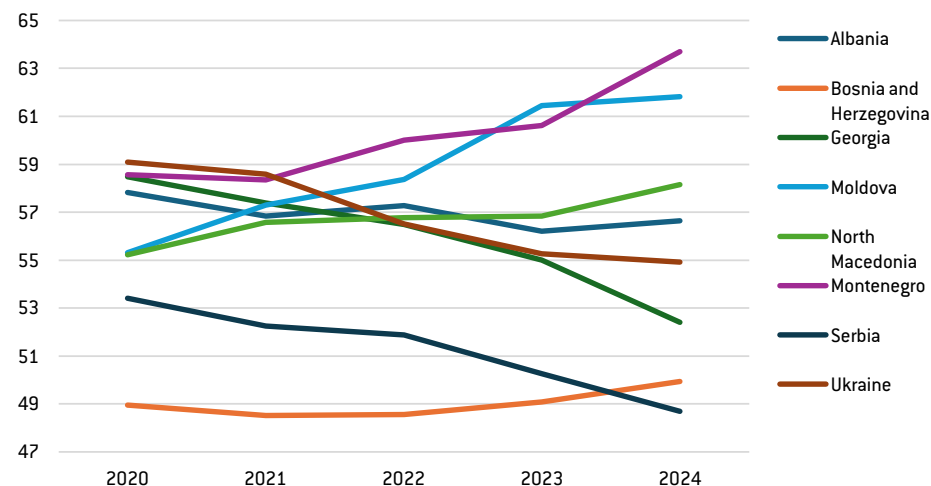
especially in the areas of political freedom and the rule of law (this is seen in Figures 10, 12 and 13). The erosion of democratic governance accelerated in 2024-2025 with the adoption of the Russian-style ‘foreign agents’ law¹¹, contested parliamentary elections in 2024, and growing repression against political opposition, media and civil society organisations.

Figure 11: Cluster 1 performance vs the average WGI (2024)



Source: Bruegel based on the World Bank.

Figure 12: World Governance Indicators, Voice and Accountability scores, 2020-2024



Source: Bruegel based on the World Bank.

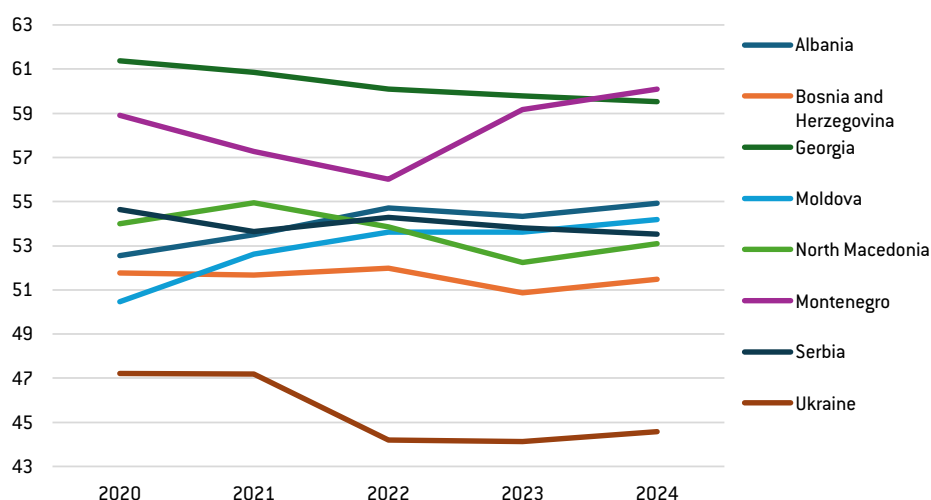
By contrast, its Cluster 1 ‘Fundamentals’ preparedness scores were lower in 2024 (Figures 3 and 11), suggesting that the Commission’s accession-related assessments have become increasingly critical regarding democratic governance, judicial

¹¹ Wojciech Górecki, ‘Georgia passes the ‘law on agents’, the internal crisis escalates’, *Analyses*, 15 May 2024, Centre for Eastern Studies, <https://www.osw.waw.pl/en/publikacje/analyses/2024-05-15/georgia-passes-law-agents-internal-crisis-escalates>.

independence and institutional checks and balances. This divergence illustrates that broader governance indicators such as the WGIs may react more slowly to recent political deterioration than EU accession assessments. One could arguably expect that these developments will be reflected in WGI scores for 2025 and 2026.

The EU accession process was subsequently suspended both by the EU institutions and the Georgian government¹² shortly after Georgia obtained EU candidate status in December 2023.

Figure 13: World Governance Indicators, Rule of Law scores, 2020-2024



Source: Bruegel based on the World Bank.

Other results of the WGI survey are largely in line with results presented in Figure 3, in terms of the reported quality of governance, changes over time and differences between individual countries (although differences between Moldova and Ukraine, on the one hand, and four Western Balkan countries are smaller than in our scores).

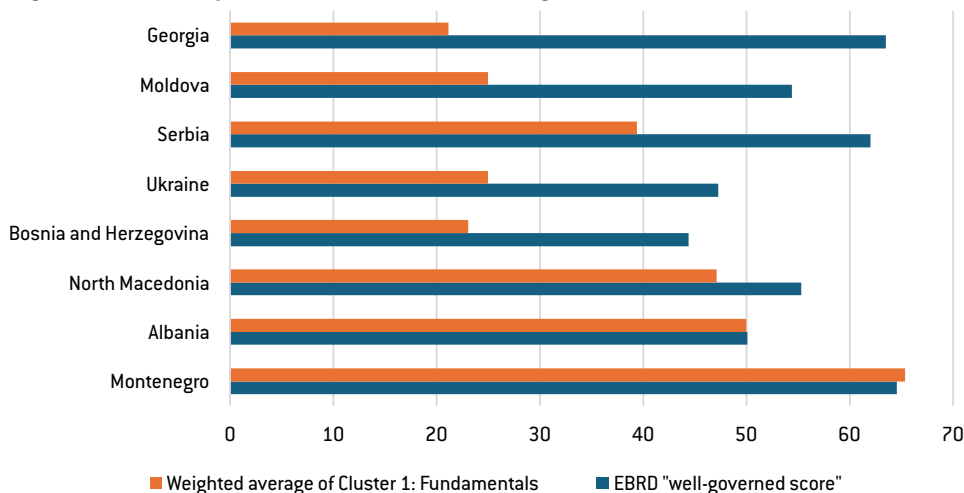
To make an additional comparison, we also present the Voice and Accountability (Figure 12) and Rule of Law (Figure 13) scores. The former is the measure of political freedom and the strength of democratic institutions and practices, and the latter characterises legal order and legal institutions. Figure 12 shows democratic backsliding in Georgia, Serbia and Ukraine (the latter likely due to the war and martial law), stagnation in Albania and Bosnia and Herzegovina, slow improvement in North Macedonia, and more visible progress in Montenegro and Moldova. Figure 13 shows backsliding in Georgia (although from a relatively high level) and Ukraine (again, likely from martial law), progress in Montenegro in 2023-2024 (after deterioration in 2020-2022), Moldova and Albania, and stagnation in other candidates.

12 Wojciech Górecki, 'Georgia is suspending its EU integration process', *Analyses*, 29 November 2024, Centre for Eastern Studies, <https://www.osw.waw.pl/en/publikacje/analyses/2024-11-29/georgia-suspending-its-eu-integration-process>.

5.2 EBRD 'well-governed' scores

In Figure 14, we compare our weighted scores for Cluster 1 of accession negotiations (Figure 3) with the EBRD 'well-governed' scores¹³. According to the EBRD, 'well-governed' is a measure of the quality of public institutions and the processes through which authority, decision-making and accountability are exercised.

Figure 14: Cluster 1 performance vs the EBRD 'well-governed' score (2025)



Source: Bruegel based on EBRD.

This measure covers public economic governance – including the rule of law, control of corruption and institutional quality – as well as corporate governance (part of Cluster 2 of the *acquis*), which deals with the rules and practices through which firms are directed and controlled. It is estimated on a scale of 1-10; for the sake of comparison in a single figure, the values are multiplied by 10.

Similar to the WGIs discussed in section 5.1, the EBRD's well-governed scores differ from our *acquis*-based measures in both purpose and methodology. While our weighted Cluster 1 scores assess progress in adopting and implementing the 'Fundamentals' cluster of the EU *acquis*, the EBRD indicator provides a broader assessment of institutional quality and governance effectiveness from the perspective of economic transition and sustainable market economy development.

The results are partly similar to our comparison between Cluster 1 weighted average scores and WGI average scores (Figure 9). The EBRD also rates Georgia much higher (in comparison with other candidates) than our analysis of weighted averages in section 4.2. The order of ranking of other countries is more in line with our findings, although the differences between them are smaller.

Georgia's outstanding (although deteriorating) performance under the EBRD 'well-governed' indicator can be explained similarly to the WGIs (see section 5.1). Differences in the content of the assessed characteristics may be another factor influencing results.

¹³ Other EBRD transition qualities (competitive, green, inclusive, integrated, and resilient) do not correspond directly to the *acquis* clusters content.

6 Preparedness for membership vs accession negotiation status

The next step in the analysis is to check whether our estimates of candidates' preparedness for EU membership are reflected in the progress of their accession negotiations (as of mid-June 2026 – see Figure 15).

After the Council's invites a candidate country to open accession negotiations, the first step involves the *acquis* screening, ie, an analytical examination of the EU *acquis* and preparing a list of reforms needed to implement them by a candidate country¹⁴. After completing the *acquis* screening, a candidate can be invited to open negotiations on the subsequent clusters, starting with Cluster 1 'Fundamentals'. Montenegro and Serbia, which started negotiations before the introduction of the Revised Enlargement Methodology, opened negotiations on individual chapters. After the adoption of the *acquis* by a candidate, a given chapter is provisionally closed. When negotiations on all chapters are completed, the accession treaty is drafted, signed and ratified by a candidate and all EU countries.

Montenegro, an EU candidate country since December 2010 and the leader in our overall weighted scores, is also the most advanced in the accession negotiations, which were opened in June 2012. By June 2020, Montenegro had all 33 negotiation chapters open. Fourteen of them (chapters 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 10, 11, 13, 20, 21, 25, 26, 30, 32) were provisionally closed¹⁵. Montenegro also met interim benchmarks in chapters 23 and 24. In November 2025, the Commission signalled the possibility of closing accession negotiations by the end of 2026¹⁶. In April 2026, the Council of the European Union established a Working Group for drafting Montenegro's Accession Treaty¹⁷.

Serbia, which opened accession negotiations in June 2013, has 22 chapters opened, but only two (chapters 25 and 26) are provisionally closed¹⁸. No new chapters have been opened since December 2021, and no chapter has been provisionally closed since February 2017.

North Macedonia¹⁹, an EU candidate since December 2005, formally opened accession negotiations in March 2020, but the First Intergovernmental Conference (IGC)

In November 2025, the Commission signalled the possibility of closing accession negotiations with Montenegro by the end of 2026

14 For a more detailed description of terms used in accession negotiations, see European Commission, 'Glossary', undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/enlargement-policy/glossary_en.

15 See European Commission factsheet on Montenegro, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/montenegro_en#eu-montenegro-relations.

16 See European Commission news of 4 November 2025, '2025 Enlargement Package shows progress towards EU membership for key enlargement partners', https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/news/2025-enlargement-package-shows-progress-towards-eu-membership-key-enlargement-partners-2025-11-04_en.

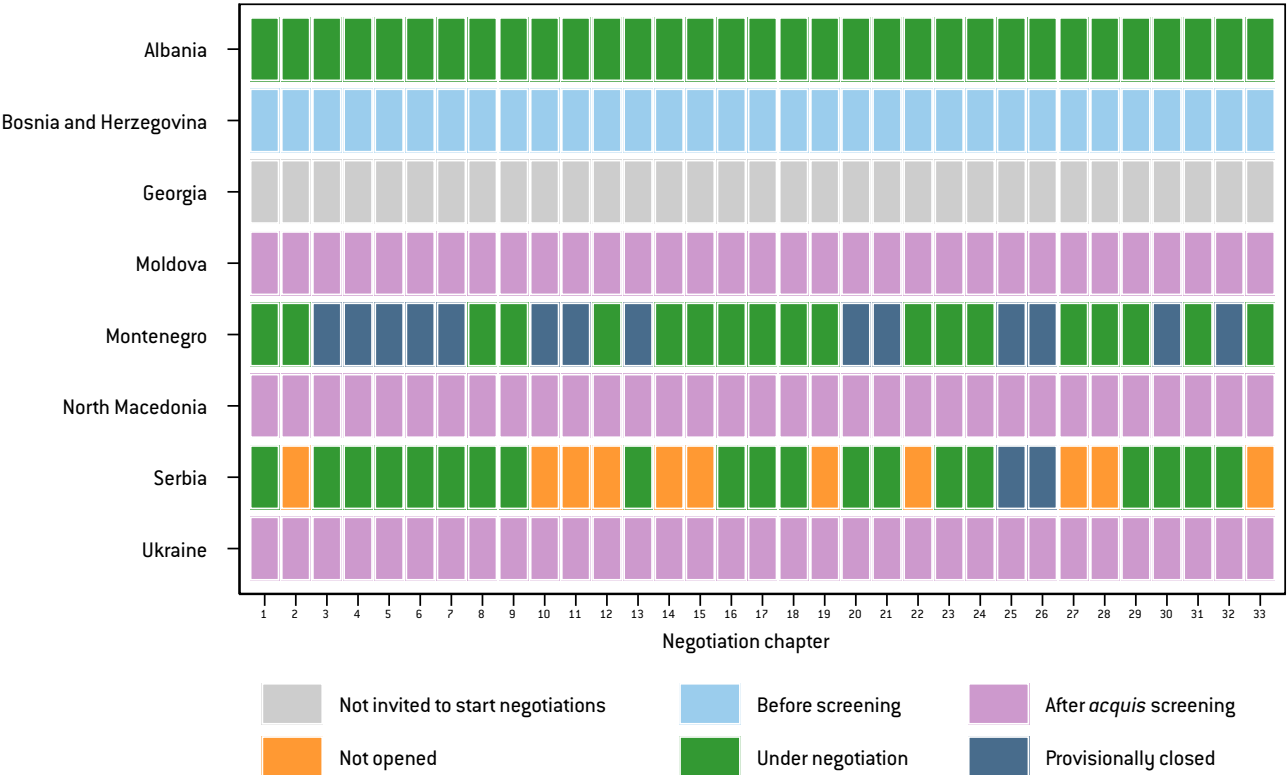
17 See EEAS press release of 24 April 2026, 'A Historic Opportunity for Montenegro to Conclude the EU Accession Process', https://www.eeas.europa.eu/delegations/montenegro/historic-opportunity-montenegro-conclude-eu-accession-process_en?s=225.

18 See European Commission factsheet on Serbia, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/serbia_en.

19 See European Commission factsheet on North Macedonia, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/north-macedonia_en.

was held only in July 2022. The resulting *acquis* screening was completed in December 2023. No further steps have been taken since then. The stalemate has been caused by the bilateral dispute with neighbouring Bulgaria on historical and cultural issues. Bulgaria demands changes in the constitution of North Macedonia to recognise the Bulgarian minority, as a condition of unblocking accession negotiations²⁰.

Figure 15: Status of EU accession negotiations by a candidate country (10 June 2026)



Source: Bruegel based on European Commission.

Similarly to North Macedonia, Albania²¹ (a candidate from June 2014) opened accession negotiations in March 2020, held the First ICG in July 2022, and completed *acquis* screening in December 2023. Fortunately, unlike North Macedonia, it could continue negotiations. It has all negotiation clusters (and chapters) opened, but none of them are provisionally closed yet. In the November 2025 enlargement package, the Commission mentioned Albania’s goal to complete accession negotiations in 2027²².

20 Marina Stoimenova, ‘Neighbourly conflicts hinder North Macedonia at the gates of the EU’, *Euronews*, 31 October 2025, <https://www.euronews.com/2025/10/31/neighbourly-conflicts-hinder-north-macedonia-at-the-gates-of-the-eu>.

21 See European Commission factsheet on Albania, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/albania_en.

22 See European Commission news of 4 November 2025, ‘2025 Enlargement Package shows progress towards EU membership for key enlargement partners’, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/news/2025-enlargement-package-shows-progress-towards-eu-membership-key-enlargement-partners-2025-11-04_en.

Ukraine²³ and Moldova²⁴, both EU candidates from June 2022, opened accession negotiations in December 2023, held the First ICGs in June 2024, and completed the screening process in September 2025. Hungary blocked opening negotiations with Ukraine on Cluster 1, and because Moldova's negotiations have been informally linked with those of Ukraine, this stalled them as well. The new government of Hungary, however, has since lifted the block. On 15 June 2026, the negotiations on Cluster 1 were opened for both countries²⁵. In the earlier quoted press release, which accompanied the 2025 enlargement package, the Commission noted the declared goals to complete negotiations by early 2028 by the Government of Moldova, and by the end of 2028 by the Government of Ukraine.

The European Council granted Bosnia and Herzegovina EU candidate status in December 2022 and approved opening accession negotiations in March 2024. No further accession steps have been taken²⁶.

Comparing the results of our analysis on Chapters 3 and 4 with the actual negotiation status of individual candidates, one can see both similarities and differences. Montenegro, the most advanced in the *acquis* adoption, is also closest to completing accession negotiations. Less reformed Albania is also less advanced in accession negotiations, although they are ongoing with respect to all clusters. Even less reformed Moldova and Ukraine are still at the very beginning of the negotiation process. Bosnia and Herzegovina, with its low level of *acquis* adoption, opened accession negotiations only formally.

Looking at discrepancies between the level of preparedness for EU membership and accession negotiation progress, North Macedonia is the most striking case. Being relatively advanced in the adoption of the EU membership-related reforms, more than 20 years after obtaining a candidate status, it cannot start accession negotiations beyond the *acquis* screening. First, it was blocked for more than a decade by Greece's demand that it change its official name. This conflict was resolved by the Prespa agreement of 2018, whereupon Macedonia changed its name to North Macedonia²⁷. Since 2020, North Macedonia's accession negotiations have been blocked by Bulgaria.

Serbia is also relatively advanced in *acquis* adoption, but it does not have prospects of becoming an EU member soon. This is a consequence of its own political and geopolitical choices: democratic backsliding, inability to normalise relations with Kosovo and fully align its foreign policy with the EU's Common Foreign and Security Policy (CFSP).

The differences between the preparedness scores and actual accession negotiation

Serbia is relatively advanced in *acquis* adoption, but is unlikely to become an EU member soon

23 See European Commission factsheet on Ukraine, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/ukraine_en.

24 See European Commission factsheet on Moldova, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/moldova_en.

25 See European Commission news of 15 June 2026, 'EU and Ukraine open first accession negotiations cluster', https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/news/eu-and-ukraine-open-first-accession-negotiations-cluster-2026-06-15_en; and of 12 June 2026, 'Statement by President von der Leyen and President Costa on the agreement to open the first accession negotiation cluster with Ukraine and Moldova', https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/news/statement-president-von-der-leyen-and-president-costa-agreement-open-first-accession-negotiation-2026-06-12_en.

26 See European Commission factsheet on Bosnia and Herzegovina, undated, https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/countries/bosnia-and-herzegovina_en.

27 The Prespa agreement is available at <https://treaties.un.org/doc/Publication/UNTS/No%20Volume/55707/Part/I-55707-0800000280544ac1.pdf>.

status are the result of political factors influencing negotiation decisions. The annual Commission reports assessing individual countries' preparedness for EU membership have a predominantly technocratic character. Decisions on each accession negotiation step require a unanimous vote by the Council of the EU or the European Council – ie all incumbent EU countries. Some of them wield their veto for domestic political reasons (for example, domestic opposition to enlargement) or as leverage in bilateral disputes with the candidate, often on issues unrelated to their candidacy.

On the other hand, political or geopolitical considerations can work to accelerate EU enlargement. This was observed immediately after Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022. The new perception of geopolitical instability in Europe resulted in granting Ukraine, Moldova and Georgia the EU candidate status and the acceleration of the accession process in the Western Balkan region. However, such positive momentum is usually time-limited.

7 Summary

This analysis, based on the Commission's annual assessments of candidates' preparedness for EU membership, and using a novel methodology of quantifying these assessments, shows that four of the Western Balkan countries (Montenegro, North Macedonia, Serbia and Albania) are more advanced in the *acquis* adoption than the three Eastern European ones. However, only Montenegro and Albania have the indicative goal of finalising membership negotiations in the foreseeable future. Montenegro may realistically complete this process by the declared deadline – the end of 2026. Albania may require more time: all clusters have been opened, but none of them have been closed.

Meanwhile, despite relative success in *acquis* adoption, North Macedonia is blocked by Bulgaria due to a bilateral dispute with no clear resolution. To revive stagnated membership negotiations, Serbia must return to the path of political and institutional reforms, especially related to Cluster 1, after recent democratic backsliding. It also must fully normalise its relations with Kosovo.

The two Eastern European candidates which started membership negotiations (Moldova and Ukraine) are behind the four Western Balkan leaders in the *acquis* adoption. Moldova has recorded visible progress since obtaining the EU candidate status in 2022; Ukraine – less so. Russia's war against Ukraine and the resulting martial law in Ukraine can explain part of this stagnation. However, there are also internal political obstacles to adopting and implementing the accession-related legislation (RRR4U, 2026).

Ukraine and (indirectly) Moldova have been blocked by Hungary's veto from opening negotiations on Cluster 1, though the new Hungarian government appointed in May 2026 has since waived these objections. However, there is still a long way to go to complete negotiations, given the still-low degree of *acquis* adoption in both countries.

Ukraine faces specific challenges related to the ongoing war. During the war, it will be difficult to adopt and implement all the *acquis*, especially those related to Clusters 1 and

4. In addition, in the context of obligations set in Article 42.7 of the Treaty on European Union²⁸, the incumbent EU countries may be reluctant to accept a new member in a state of active war (Darvas *et al*, 2024).

The accession perspectives of two other candidates analysed in our paper are even more unclear. Bosnia and Herzegovina, despite being invited to open accession negotiations in March 2024, is struggling to meet several institutional preconditions set by the Council of the EU. Its degree of *acquis* adoption is very low, as shown in sections 3 and 4. Georgia's scores look a bit better, but its accession process was frozen in 2024, before formal negotiations opened, due to democratic backsliding and increasing divergence from the EU CFSP.

Looking ahead, maintaining the momentum for enlargement generated by recent geopolitical events – Russian aggression, an increasingly isolationist United States, the rise of China – is in the interest of both candidate and incumbent EU countries. Adopting the *acquis* now is more difficult than for those who joined the EU in 2004, 2007 and 2011. The reason is simple: the EU is now more institutionally developed and integrated than 25 years ago. Therefore, candidates require more political, financial, and technical support in their adoption of the *acquis* and stronger incentives to move in this direction (sometimes against the opposition of various domestic interest groups).

Regarding incentives, the most important one is the accession negotiations themselves. They should be maximally merit-based and free of attempts to use them by the incumbent EU countries for domestic political purposes or in bilateral disputes with a candidate on issues unrelated to accession. Achieving such a goal would require eliminating the unanimity requirement for enlargement-related decisions in favour of qualified majority voting (QMV).

Maintaining the momentum for enlargement generated by recent geopolitical events is in the interest of both candidate and incumbent EU countries

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28 Article 42(7) of the Treaty on European Union obliges other member states to provide a victim of aggression "... aid and assistance by all the means in their power"; see EEAS, 'Article 42(7) TEU - The EU's mutual assistance clause', 6 October 2022, https://www.eeas.europa.eu/eeas/article-427-teu-eus-mutual-assistance-clause_en.

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